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DESIGN CODE NS 01

Hamish the Highland Cow

US crochet terms · Intermediate · 15 cm / 6 in sitting · 6-8 hours

A shaggy, sturdy Highland cow with a flattened brow, a wide cream muzzle and a weather-beaten fringe. Worked in pieces and assembled, so every proportion can be pinned and checked before it is sewn.

SAFETY — READ THIS FIRST

Hamish has **two 12 mm safety eyes**. Safety eyes are small parts. Lock the washers firmly from the inside and pull-test each one on the finished toy — a properly locked washer will not come off by hand. This pattern locks them after the muzzle is sewn, which is the right order: you cannot re-position an eye once the washer is on.

The horns, ears, muzzle, legs and tail are all **sewn on**, and the fringe and tail are **knotted yarn**. Sew every seam twice, weave every end in for at least 5 cm, and knot the fringe and tail securely. Loose strands are the first thing a child will pull.

This pattern has not been tested to a toy-safety standard such as ASTM F963 or EN 71, so please do not describe finished Hamishes as "baby-safe" or "suitable from birth" in your listings. **For children under three, embroider the eyes** with black floss instead of using safety eyes.

MATERIALS

Yarn A — Ginger. Worsted / aran (#4). The whole cow uses about **25 g**; one 80 g / 150 m ball covers it several times over, which is what you want if you plan to make more than one or to re-do the fringe. Caramel, toffee or ginger gold.

Yarn B — Oat cream. Worsted / aran (#4), about **12 g**. Muzzle, horns, inner ears, optional belly patch.

Yarn C — Dark chocolate. Worsted / aran (#4), about **5 g**. Hooves and nostrils.

Yarn D — Rust. Optional, about **6 g** for the scarf, or 28 cm of 12 mm tartan ribbon.

Hook — 3.5 mm (US E-4). Smaller than the ball band so stuffing cannot show.

Eyes — 2 × 12 mm black safety eyes, or embroider for under-threes.

Stuffing — Polyester fiber fill, about **30 g**. Hamish holds roughly 405 cm³; at a firm pack that is 22–32 g. The head and body alone take about 20 g packed firmly. Buying 50 g gives you room to over-stuff the base, which is what makes him sit.

Notions — Stitch marker, tapestry needle, pins, scissors.

GAUGE & FINISHED SIZE

Gauge — 11 sc × 12 rounds = 5 cm / 2 in in Yarn A (4.55 mm per stitch, 4.17 mm per round). Not critical, but loose tension lets stuffing show — drop half a millimetre if your fabric is gappy.

Finished size — About 15 cm / 6 in sitting in the worsted version, with a 70 mm wide body and a 70 × 67 mm head.

ABBREVIATIONS

MR magic ring · **ch** chain · **sl st** slip stitch · **sc** single crochet · **hdc** half double crochet · **inc** 2 sc in one stitch · **dec** invisible decrease · **BLO** back loop only · **FO** fasten off · **(n)** stitch count

Work in a continuous spiral unless a round says join. Mark the first stitch of every round. Leave 30–40 cm tails on every piece you will sew.

CORE TECHNIQUES

These are the techniques Hamish uses, in the order you will meet them.

1 • THE MAGIC RING. Wrap the yarn once around two fingers, insert the hook, pull up a loop and work the first round into the ring, then pull the tail to close it. Pull the tail tight once the first round is complete.

2 • WORK IN A SPIRAL. Do not join and do not ch 1 between rounds. Keep a stitch marker in the first stitch of every round and move it up each time — there is no join to count from.

3 • THE INVISIBLE DECREASE. Insert the hook through the **front loops only** of the next two stitches, yarn over and pull through both, then yarn over and pull through the remaining two loops. Every dec in this pattern is worked this way; it leaves no ridge on the visible rounds.

4 • BACK LOOP ONLY (BLO). Work into the far loop of the stitch only, leaving the near loop unused. The unused loops form a raised ridge. Hamish's hoof line is one BLO round.

5 • WORKING AROUND A CHAIN (the oval). For the belly patch you crochet into both sides of a starting chain: work across the front of the chain, put the corner increases into the last chain, then continue back along the opposite side and finish into the last remaining loop. That is what turns a chain into a flat oval instead of a strip.

6 • THE LARK'S HEAD KNOT. Fold a strand in half, push the folded loop under a stitch with your hook, then pull the two loose ends through the loop and cinch. Used for every fringe strand and for the tail.

7 • LADDER STITCH. The invisible seam. Bring the needle out on one side, pick up one stitch bar on the opposite side, then one bar back on the first side, alternating, and pull snug every few stitches. The head-to-body join needs two full passes.

1. HEAD · YARN A · MAKE 1

Worked from the top of the head down toward the neck. One straight round only — this is what keeps the brow flat and wide instead of egg-shaped.

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	NOTE
Rnd 1	6 sc in MR	(6)	
Rnd 2	inc in each st around	(12)	
Rnd 3	[sc, inc] ×6	(18)	
Rnd 4	[2 sc, inc] ×6	(24)	
Rnd 5	[3 sc, inc] ×6	(30)	
Rnd 6	[4 sc, inc] ×6	(36)	fringe row 3
Rnd 7	[5 sc, inc] ×6	(42)	fringe row 2 / horns
Rnd 8	[6 sc, inc] ×6	(48)	fringe row 1 / ears
Rnd 9	sc in each st around	(48)	eyes at Rnd 9-10
Rnd 10	[6 sc, dec] ×6	(42)	
Rnd 11	[5 sc, dec] ×6	(36)	
Rnd 12	[4 sc, dec] ×6	(30)	stuff firmly, flatten front to back
Rnd 13	[3 sc, dec] ×6	(24)	
Rnd 14	[2 sc, dec] ×6	(18)	
Rnd 15	[sc, dec] ×6	(12)	last pinch of stuffing
Rnd 16	dec ×6	(6)	

Finish. FO. Close the hole with the tail.

Eyes. Place the 12 mm safety eyes between Rnds 9 and 10, 7 stitches apart and a touch low on the face. Seven stitches is about 32 mm, just under half the head width. Leave the washers off until the muzzle is pinned.

Finished head measures about 70 mm wide × 67 mm tall — a flattened sphere at 0.96 height-to-width, which is the Highland silhouette.

2. MUZZLE · YARN B · MAKE 1

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	NOTE
Rnd 1	6 sc in MR	(6)	
Rnd 2	inc in each st around	(12)	
Rnd 3	[sc, inc] ×6	(18)	
Rnd 4	[2 sc, inc] ×6	(24)	
Rnd 5	sc in each st around	(24)	face at full width, 35 mm
Rnd 6	sc in each st around	(24)	
Rnd 7	sc in each st around	(24)	
Rnd 8	[2 sc, dec] ×6	(18)	rim = 26 mm across

Finish. FO, 40 cm tail. Stuff lightly.

Pinning. The muzzle **face** is about 35 mm across — that is the wide cream patch you see. The **rim** it is sewn by is about 26 mm, which on this gauge spans roughly six rounds of head.

Pin the top edge just under the eyes at **Rnd 10** and let the lower edge fall at **Rnd 15-16**, near the chin. Center it and let the face sit a little wider than the eye spacing. Sew with small whip stitches, adding a whisper more stuffing before you close.

Nostrils (Yarn C). Two short vertical satin stitches, 3 stitches apart, on the lower third. **Mouth.** One tiny horizontal stitch or a shallow V below them. **Lock the safety-eye washers now.**

3. BODY · YARN A · MAKE 1

Worked from the bottom up toward the neck.

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	NOTE
Rnd 1	6 sc in MR	(6)	
Rnd 2	inc in each st around	(12)	
Rnd 3	[sc, inc] ×6	(18)	
Rnd 4	[2 sc, inc] ×6	(24)	
Rnd 5	[3 sc, inc] ×6	(30)	
Rnd 6	[4 sc, inc] ×6	(36)	
Rnd 7	[5 sc, inc] ×6	(42)	
Rnd 8	[6 sc, inc] ×6	(48)	front legs join at Rnd 8-9
Rnd 9	sc in each st around	(48)	
Rnd 10	sc in each st around	(48)	body at full width, 70 mm
Rnd 11	sc in each st around	(48)	
Rnd 12	sc in each st around	(48)	
Rnd 13	sc in each st around	(48)	
Rnd 14	[6 sc, dec] ×6	(42)	
Rnd 15	sc in each st around	(42)	
Rnd 16	[5 sc, dec] ×6	(36)	
Rnd 17	[4 sc, dec] ×6	(30)	stuff firmly, pack the base
Rnd 18	[3 sc, dec] ×6	(24)	
Rnd 19	[2 sc, dec] ×6	(18)	leave neck OPEN

Finish. FO, 40 cm tail. Do not close.

Body height is now 19 rounds ≈ 79 mm, and the head adds about 67 mm. With the head seated on the neck ring the finished sitting height is about 15 cm / 6 in.

4. BELLY PATCH · YARN B · OPTIONAL

A two-tone belly. Skip it for a plain ginger front — both are correct.

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	NOTE
Foundation	ch 9	chain only	

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	NOTE
Rnd 1	sc in 2nd ch from hook, sc in next 6, 3 sc in last ch, sc in next 6, 2 sc in last loop (18)		worked around both sides of the chain
Rnd 2	inc, 6 sc, inc ×3, 6 sc, inc ×2 (24)		
Rnd 3	sc, inc, 6 sc, [sc, inc] ×3, 6 sc, [sc, inc] ×2 (30)		
Rnd 4	2 sc, inc, 6 sc, [2 sc, inc] ×3, 6 sc, [2 sc, inc] ×2 (36)		

Finish. Sl st to next st. FO, long tail. Sew centered on the front of the body with the lower edge about 3 rounds up from the base.

5. LEGS · MAKE 4 · START YARN C

All four legs are identical; the sitting pose comes from where and at what angle you sew them. Sixteen rounds gives a 67 mm leg.

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	NOTE
Rnd 1	6 sc in MR (6)		Yarn C
Rnd 2	inc in each st around (12)		
Rnd 3	[sc, inc] ×6 (18)		
Rnd 4	sc in each st around (18)		
Rnd 5	sc in each st around (18)		
Rnd 6	BLO sc around (18)		change to Yarn A — ridge = colour line
Rnd 7	sc in each st around (18)		
Rnd 8	[sc, dec] ×6 (12)		stuff hoof firmly
Rnd 9	sc in each st around (12)		
Rnd 10	sc in each st around (12)		
Rnd 11	sc in each st around (12)		
Rnd 12	sc in each st around (12)		
Rnd 13	sc in each st around (12)		upper leg light
Rnd 14	[2 sc, dec] ×3 (9)		
Rnd 15	sc in each st around (9)		
Rnd 16	sc in each st around (9)		

Finish. FO, 30 cm tail. Leave the top open.

Hoof ridge. The BLO round and the colour change happen on the same round (Rnd 6), so the ridge lands exactly on the cream-to-ginger line and reads as the rim of the hoof.

Leg length — read this before you sew. The legs are 67 mm long, and the joins are much lower than that: the front join at Rnd 8–9 is about 33–37 mm above the body base, and the back join at Rnd 3–6 is only 12–25 mm above it. A 67 mm leg therefore has to splay a long way from straight down before its hoof lands on the surface — about **55° from vertical at the front** and about **68–70° at the back**, which is close to horizontal and out to the side. That is the low, sprawling Highland sit.

If you would rather have a tidier, more upright sit with the hooves just in front of the chest, work the **front pair only to Rnd 10 and stop there** (42 mm). At that length they reach the surface at a natural 20–25° angle. Leave the back pair at 16 rounds as haunches. Pin all four before you sew anything.

6. EARS · MAKE 2 OF EACH LAYER

Both layers reach 12 stitches so Rnd 4 can be worked through both.

Inner (Yarn B), make 2

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
Rnd 1	6 sc in MR (6)	

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
Rnd 2	[sc, inc] ×3	(9)
Rnd 3	[2 sc, inc] ×3	(12)

Outer (Yarn A), make 2

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
Rnd 1	6 sc in MR	(6)
Rnd 2	[sc, inc] ×3	(9)
Rnd 3	[2 sc, inc] ×3	(12)
Rnd 4	sc in each st around	(12)
Rnd 5	sc in each st around	(12)
Rnd 6	[2 sc, dec] ×3	(9)
Rnd 7	sc in each st around	(9)

Finish. Flatten. FO, leave a tail.

Place the inner on the outer, cream side facing you, before Rnd 4. Flatten, FO, and pinch the base with 2–3 stitches so the ear cups forward.

7. HORNS · MAKE 2 · YARN B

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
Rnd 1	4 sc in MR	(4)
Rnd 2	[sc, inc] ×2	(6)
Rnd 3	sc in each st around	(6)
Rnd 4	sc in each st around	(6)
Rnd 5	[2 sc, inc] ×2	(8)
Rnd 6	sc in each st around	(8)
Rnd 7	sc in each st around	(8)

Finish. Stuff the tip only. FO, leave a tail.

Short and slightly curved — tilt each one out and a little back when you sew.

8. TAIL · YARN A

Cut 6 strands of Yarn A, each 22 cm / 8.5 in. Fold the bundle in half, pull the folded loop through a stitch at the center-back just above the last increase round of the body, and pull the tails through the loop (lark's head). Folding the bundle gives you 12 hanging ends; divide them into 3 groups of 4 and braid for 4 cm. Knot firmly and trim into a small tassel.

9. THE FRINGE · YARN A

Attach after the horns and ears are sewn so you can part the hair around them.

Cut 44 strands of Yarn A, each 14 cm / 5.5 in. For depth, swap 6 of them for Yarn C. Attach with a lark's head knot: fold a strand in half, insert the hook under a stitch, grab the folded loop, pull it through, then pull both tails through the loop and cinch.

Work a horseshoe from one ear, across the brow, to the other ear, filling three rows on Rnds 8, 7 and 6 of the head: every stitch on Rnd 8 (the front row), then every other stitch on Rnds 7 and 6. Across a half-round horseshoe that is about $24 + 10 + 9 = 43$ knots, which is what the 44 strands are for.

Tousle with your fingers. Trim so the fringe grazes the eyes and breaks into uneven points. Highland hair is weather-beaten, not a salon fringe — if it looks tidy, it is not finished.

10. OPTIONAL TARTAN SCARF · YARN D

Ch 61. **Row 1:** hdc in 2nd ch from hook and in each ch across (60). **Row 2:** ch 1, turn, hdc across (60). FO.

Add a 3-strand tassel at each end, or weave a second colour in a slip-stitch stripe to hint at tartan. Tie loosely under the muzzle.

Ribbon shortcut: 28 cm of 12 mm rust tartan ribbon, knotted once.

ASSEMBLY

Pin everything before you sew. Photograph the pinned piece — it is the best pattern note you will ever make.

1 • Muzzle & face. Already done if you followed section 2.

2 • Horns. Sew between Rnds 5 and 7, 6 stitches apart, angled out and slightly back.

3 • Ears. Sew just outside and a little below each horn, centered on Rnds 8–9, cupped forward.

4 • Fringe. Attach and trim as in section 9.

5 • Head to body. Sit the closed head on the open neck (Rnd 19 of the body, an 18-stitch ring about 26 mm across). Because the head is fully closed this is a ball-on-ring join with no flat seat, and the ring only grips the head about 8 mm up from its base — so it carries real weight on a shallow purchase. Ladder-stitch all the way around **twice**, pack the neck firmly before you start, and tilt the muzzle a few degrees down as if Hamish is listening.

6 • Back legs. Sew to the lower sides of the body across Rnds 3–6, almost on the base, splayed out to the side. From a join this low a 67 mm leg needs about 68–70° from vertical before the hoof is level with the base, so they end up close to horizontal — that is what makes him sit.

7 • Front legs. Sew to the FRONT of the body across Rnds 8–9, about 8 stitches apart, angled forward and down — about 55° from vertical, per the note in section 5. Joined any higher, the hooves dangle.

8 • Belly patch. Only if you made it.

9 • Tail • 10 • Scarf. Weave in every end and squeeze to settle the stuffing. A shot of cool air from a hairdryer will fluff the fringe.

THREE SIZES, ONE PATTERN

VERSION	YARN	HOOK	EYES	HEIGHT	YARN A	STUFFING
Wee Hamish	DK / #3	2.75 mm	8–9 mm	~12 cm	50 g	~15 g
Classic	Worsted / #4	3.5 mm	12 mm	~15 cm	80 g	~30 g
Cuddle Hamish	Bulky chenille / #5	5.0 mm	16–18 mm	~21 cm	160 g	~80 g

Stitch counts stay the same. Only the yarn, hook and stuffing change. Because the stitch count is fixed, yarn scales with the **square** of the height and stuffing with the **cube** — so the Cuddle version needs far more of both than it first appears, and chenille covers fewer metres per gram than worsted on top of that. Buy generously for the big one.

TROUBLESHOOTING

He will not sit. Restuff the body base more firmly and sew the back legs lower and wider — closer to horizontal than you think.

Front hooves float. They are sewn too high. They belong on Rnds 8–9 of the body, not under the neck. If they still float, the legs are simply too long for the join: work the front pair to Rnd 10 (section 5).

Stuffing shows. Drop half a hook size, or hold a matching thread with the yarn on visible rounds.

Face looks blank. The eyes are too high. Low eyes plus a wide muzzle is the Highland stare.

Fringe is sparse. Add a fourth row behind the horns, and mix in one darker shade.

Horns flop. Under-stuffed at the tip, or sewn only at the edge. Stitch a full round into the head fabric.

Head tips forward. The neck ring is small relative to the head and only grips it about 8 mm up. Pack the neck before closing and make the second ladder-stitch pass tight.

THE FINISHED PROJECT

All pieces before assembly. Lay every component out and check it against the pattern before you sew anything: 1 head, 1 muzzle, 1 body, 4 legs, 2 inner and 2 outer ears, 2 horns, a tail and a fringe — plus the belly patch and scarf if you are making them.

Finished project. Hamish sitting, with the front hooves flat on the surface.

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